

Aegle marmelos (Rutaceae)

Bael, Bengal Quince

Description Thorny deciduous tree growing to 26 ft (8 m). Has aromatic oval- to lance-shaped leaves, greenish-white flowers, and yellow plum-shaped fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to India, bael grows throughout much of Southeast Asia in dry forests. It is also cultivated throughout the region.

Parts Used Fruit, leaves, root, twigs.

Constituents Bael contains coumarins, flavonoids, alkaloids, tannins, carotinoids, and volatile oil.

History & Folklore The bael tree is sacred to the Hindu deities Lakshmi (the goddess of wealth and good fortune) and Shiva (the god of health), and it is commonly planted near temples. Its medicinal virtues are described in the *Charaka Samhita*, an herbal text written c. 400 BCE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The astringent half-ripe bael fruit reduces irritation in the digestive tract and is excellent for diarrhea and dysentery. The ripe fruit is demulcent and laxative, with a significant vitamin C content. It eases stomach pain and supports the healthy function of this organ. Bael's astringent leaves are taken to treat peptic ulcers. The tree's most unusual application is for earache. A piece of dried root is dipped in the oil of the neem tree (*Azadirachta indica*, p. 70) and set alight. Oil from the burning end is dripped into the ear. (This is not a recommended practice.)

Self-help Use Diarrhea, p. 307.

Agastache rugosa (Lamiaceae)

Korean Mint, Huo Xiang (Chinese)

Description Aromatic perennial or biennial herb growing to 4 ft (1.2 m). Has a square stem, triangular leaves, and purple flowers growing in dense spikes.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China and also found in Japan, Korea, Laos, and Russia, Korean mint grows wild on slopes and roadsides. It is cultivated throughout China and gathered in summer.

Parts Used Aerial parts.

Constituents Korean mint contains a volatile oil, including methylchavicol, anethole, anisaldehyde, and limonene.

History & Folklore Korean mint was first mentioned in a Chinese medicinal text—Tao Hongjing's revision of the *Divine Husbandman's Classic* (*Shen'ong Bencaojing*), which he wrote in about 500 CE.

Medicinal Actions & Uses The acrid Korean mint is considered a warming herb in Oriental herbal medicine (see pp. 40–43) and is used to treat "dampness" within the digestive system. In Korea, as its name suggests, the leaves are eaten as a condiment to aid digestion. The herb stimulates and warms the digestive tract, relieving symptoms such as abdominal bloating, indigestion, nausea, and vomiting. It is commonly used to relieve vomiting and morning sickness. Korean mint is used to treat the early stages of viral infections that feature symptoms such as stomachache and nausea. A lotion containing Korean mint may be applied to fungal conditions such as ringworm.

Research Laboratory experiments indicate that Korean mint has marked activity against fungal infections.

Related Species In southern China and Taiwan, *Pogostemon cablin* is used interchangeably with Korean mint. *P. cablin* is a close relative of the Indian plant *P. patchouli*, from which patchouli oil is produced.



Korean mint is used to treat fungal infections such as ringworm.

Agave americana (Agavaceae)

Agave, Century Plant

Description Succulent perennial with large rosette of 30–60 fleshy, sharply toothed leaves that reach a height of 6½ ft (2 m). After 10 years or more, clusters of yellow flowers, growing to 2¾ in (7 cm) across, bloom on a pole-like stem 26–30 ft (8–9 m) tall.

Habitat & Cultivation Agave is native to deserts of Central America. It is now grown as an ornamental plant in tropical and subtropical areas around the world.

Part Used Sap.

Constituents Agave sap contains estrogen-like isoflavonoids, alkaloids, coumarins, and vitamins pro-A, B₁, B₂, C, D, and K.

History & Folklore Unlike Europeans at the time of the Spanish conquest of America, the Aztec and Maya people were skilled in wound healing. They used agave sap (often with egg white) to bind powders and gums in pastes or poultices to be applied to wounds. The *Badianus Manuscript* (1552 CE), which was the first herbal text to list the plants of the New World, describes an Aztec treatment for diarrhea and dysentery, in which agave juice, combined with freshly ground maize (*Zea mays*, p. 154) and extract of bladderwort (*Utricularia* species), is given as an enema, using a syringe made from the bladder of a small animal and a hollow bone or reed. Both tequila and mescal, popular Mexican alcoholic drinks, are distilled from the fermented sap or juice of agaves.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Demulcent, laxative, and antiseptic, agave sap is a soothing and restorative remedy for many digestive ailments. It is used to treat ulcers and inflammatory conditions affecting the stomach and intestines, protecting these parts from infection and irritation and encouraging healing. Agave has also been employed to treat many other conditions, including constipation, jaundice, liver disease, and tuberculosis.

Related Species Agave is a fairly close relative of aloe (*Aloe vera*, p. 60). The two plants have similar medicinal uses. The sisal agave (*A. sisalana*) is cultivated in subtropical America and in Kenya as a source of hecogenin, the substance that is the starting point in the production of corticosteroids (steroid hormones).

Cautions Do not use during pregnancy. Do not exceed the dose as this may cause digestive irritation and eventual liver damage. External use may cause skin irritation.